

**FITNESSWISE**

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Of style and (no) substance

With stringent anti-doping measures in place, athletes must navigate the **risky terrain of sports supplements** with extreme caution.

People have long been subjected to drug tests for supplements and drinks, and the situation is worsening over the years, with many athletes facing scrutiny for substance abuse. International competitions like the Olympics involves mandatory drug testing in most sports, such as weightlifting, boxing, tennis and athletics.

The global organisation responsible for drug testing in both Olympic and non-Olympic sports is the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA). **WADA maintains a regularly updated list of banned substances, any of which, if found in an athlete's system, could lead to either a suspension or a lifetime ban.**

There are a few obvious items on this list, such as various forms of testosterone and narcotics. It's best for athletes to check this list on the WADA website to stay consistently informed about the supplements and substances that they use.

Most athletes take workout supplements such as protein powder, amino acids, or creatine, while others prefer pre-workout drinks before training. However, they may mistakenly believe that they are adhering to the rules, thinking that

these items are neither anabolic steroids nor amphetamines.

But the issue is that companies that produce these supplements and drinks often include banned substances, knowingly or unknowingly, to enhance its effectiveness. Such information may not be disclosed on the product label since these companies are not legally bound to list all ingredients. In another possible scenario, a supplement may be manufactured in the same facility and equipment that contain banned substances. It's a tricky situation for athletes, since they can unknowingly take contaminated supplements, leading to failed drug tests and suspensions.

Supplement companies want to maximise profits, and the best way to do that is by endorsing products through trainers, players, and celebrities. Due to lack of proper regulations, these companies can include whatever ingredients they want in their supplements and drinks; it's essentially an open playing field. Every competitive athlete needs to be aware of this reality. And, even if they conduct extensive research on a product, there are no guarantees of its cleanliness. Therefore, the responsibility ultimately falls on the

athletes. If they fail a drug test and plead with WADA, the response from the organisation will always be the same. Also, taking legal action against the supplement company may be challenging, as there is no legal basis to rely on.

WADA's website clearly states: "WADA is not involved in any certification process regarding supplements and therefore does not certify or endorse manufacturers or their products. WADA does not control the quality or the claims of the supplements industry, which may, from time to time, claim that their products have been approved or certified by WADA. If a company wishes to promote its products to the sport community, it is their responsibility as a manufacturer to ensure that the products do not lead to any anti-doping rule violation. Some third-party testers of supplements exist, and this may reduce the risk of contamination but not eliminate it."

If you are an athlete who is considering taking a supplement, my recommendation would be to check whether tested athletes who have used the exact product have not encountered any issues. Also, it's best to consult with a sports nutritionist, physiotherapist, and a